Thorat had then addressed the troops, said much the same thing and departed. ‘If the army commander said this in 1960, how come we claim we were not prepared?’ I asked incredulously.

‘I don’t know,’ said my father, ‘but there was talk of a war game conducted by General Thorat in 1961 where everyone other than the prime minister was supposed to have been present. I think it was called Exercise Lal Qila. There was also some talk of a Thorat Plan that drew a defensive line along the lower reaches that were supposed to be our defensible points. But at our level, all this was just talk.’

Since 1992 I have been working on various films on the history of the Indian Armed Forces. I began to realize then how little information there was about the actual events around 1962. For me, Nam Ka Chu had been the most poignant of them all because it concerned 2 Rajput, the battalion I was born into. But there were so many other units and events that one knew nothing of: 1 Sikh at Bum-la and Tawang, 4 Garhwal Rifles at Nuranang, 4 Sikh LI at Se-la, the Assam Rifles and 5 Guards at Poshing-la, the panic at Dirang Dzong, again 5 Guards at Thembang, 3 JAK Rifles at Bomdila and 4 Rajput at Lagyala Gompa in the Kameng Frontier Division; 2 Assam Rifles at Kibithu, 6 Kumaon at the Ashi Nullah and Yellow Pimple, 3/3 GR at The Ladders, and 4 Sikh at Walong in the Lohit Frontier Division, to say nothing of the Siang and Subansiri Frontier Divisions of NEFA. And then there were the battles fought in Ladakh, extending from the Demchok area to the Spanggur Gap, and then across the Aksai Chin region to the Galwan River Valley and the Qara Qash region to the Karakoram Pass and Daulat Beg Oldi.

Even back then I was aware that if I wanted to tell the story of what happened in that one month, I would have to try and peel through various layers of history, rumour, myths, half-truths and outright lies to understand why events played out the way they did. Even more importantly, I felt that unless one actually visited the locations, the complete picture could never emerge. If that logic was to apply, then apart from the various regions of NEFA, it would mean visiting East Sikkim, the Sikkim Plateau, parts of Kumaon and Garhwal, Lahaul and Spiti and the remotest corners of Nubra, Ladakh and even Zanskar.

It would take me three decades to complete the task.